STUDENT WELLNESS

Student Burnout Recovery Plan

Identifying burnout, rebuilding energy, and creating sustainable habits

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A Note from Dr. Hala

Dear student,

Burnout is not laziness. It is what happens when you have been running on empty for too long, when the demands on your time, energy, and emotional reserves exceed your ability to replenish them.

If you are reading this, you are probably already feeling it: the exhaustion that sleep does not fix, the cynicism about things you used to care about, the sense that no matter how hard you work, it is never enough.

This plan is designed to help you recognize burnout, understand what caused it, and take concrete steps toward recovery. You did not arrive here overnight, and you will not recover overnight either. But every small step matters.

With warmth, **Dr. Hala Ali** *Family & Youth Counselor*

Section 1: Recognizing Burnout

The Three Dimensions of Burnout

1. **Exhaustion:** Physical, emotional, and mental depletion. You feel tired even after resting.
2. **Cynicism:** Detachment and negativity toward your studies, activities, or relationships. Things that used to excite you now feel meaningless.
3. **Reduced efficacy:** The feeling that nothing you do makes a difference. Your confidence in your own abilities drops.

Burnout Self-Assessment

Rate each statement from 1 (never) to 5 (always):

Physical Signs

- I feel physically exhausted most days _____
- I get sick more often than usual (colds, headaches, stomach issues) _____
- I have trouble sleeping, or I sleep too much and still feel tired _____
- My appetite has changed significantly (eating too much or too little) _____
- I rely on caffeine, sugar, or other stimulants to get through the day _____

Emotional Signs

- I feel emotionally numb or disconnected _____
- I dread going to class or doing schoolwork _____
- I feel irritable or short-tempered with people I care about _____

- I feel like crying for no clear reason _____
- I feel anxious even about small tasks _____

Cognitive and Behavioral Signs

- I have trouble concentrating even on things I enjoy _____
- I have withdrawn from friends or activities _____
- I feel like my efforts do not matter _____
- I procrastinate on things I used to handle easily _____
- I cannot remember the last time I felt truly rested _____

Scoring:

- **15-30:** Mild to moderate stress. You are not in burnout yet, but you are heading in that direction. Now is the time to intervene.
- **31-50:** Warning zone. You are showing clear signs of burnout. Please take this seriously and begin the recovery steps below.
- **51-75:** Burnout territory. Please seek support from a counselor, trusted adult, or campus wellness service. You do not have to do this alone.

Section 2: Understanding Your Burnout

Common Causes for Students

- Academic overload without adequate breaks
- Perfectionism and fear of failure
- Lack of social support or meaningful connection
- Financial stress or working while studying
- Family expectations and cultural pressure
- Comparison with high-achieving peers
- Loss of autonomy, feeling like your life is not your own
- Taking on too many extracurriculars to build a resume
- A difficult home environment that drains your energy before the school day even starts

The Burnout Equation

Burnout = High Demands + Low Resources + Low Recovery

To recover, you need to address all three parts: reduce demands where possible, increase your resources and support, and prioritize recovery.

Energy Audit Worksheet

To understand your burnout, you need to know where your energy is going. For one week, track your daily activities and rate whether each one gives you energy (+) or drains it (-).

Day: _____

Time	Activity	Energy (+/-)	Notes
Morning			
Late morning			
Afternoon			
Late afternoon			
Evening			
Night			

After one week, look at the patterns:

- **Which activities drain me most?** _____
- **Which activities give me energy?** _____
- **Am I spending most of my time on draining activities?** _____
- **When was the last time I did something purely for enjoyment?** _____
- **What is one draining activity I could reduce, delegate, or drop?** _____
- **What is one energizing activity I could add to my week?** _____

Section 3: The Recovery Plan

Week 1-2: Emergency Measures

These are immediate actions to stop the bleeding:

1. **Cancel one thing.** Look at your schedule and remove the lowest-priority commitment. Give yourself permission. Write it here: I am letting go of _____ this week.
2. **Set a hard stop time each night.** No studying after this hour. Non-negotiable. My stop time is _____.
3. **Sleep.** This is not optional. Aim for 7-8 hours. Burnout recovery starts with rest. Set a bedtime alarm on your phone.

4. **Move your body gently.** A 15-minute walk. Stretching. Yoga. Nothing intense. The goal is to get out of your head and into your body.
5. **Reach out to one person.** Tell someone you trust how you are feeling. You do not need to have it all figured out. Just say: "I am struggling and I wanted someone to know."

Week 1-2 Check-in:

- Did I cancel or reduce one commitment? _____
- Am I honoring my stop time most nights? _____
- How is my sleep? (1 = terrible, 5 = restful): _____
- Did I move my body at least 3 times this week? _____
- Did I talk to someone about how I am feeling? _____

Week 3-4: Rebuilding

1. **Audit your commitments.** What can you drop, delegate, or postpone? Use the energy audit above to guide you.
2. **Reintroduce one enjoyable activity.** Something that is not productive, just pleasurable. Drawing, cooking, watching a movie, playing a game. Write it here: _____ .
3. **Create a sustainable study schedule.** One that includes breaks, buffer time, and days off. If your old schedule burned you out, the answer is not a better version of the same schedule. It is a fundamentally different approach.
4. **Practice saying no.** Start small. Build the muscle. Here is a script: "Thank you for thinking of me. I do not have the capacity for that right now."
5. **Eat regular meals.** Burnout recovery requires fuel. If cooking feels like too much, keep simple options on hand: fruit, nuts, yogurt, bread and cheese. Do not let perfect be the enemy of fed.

Week 3-4 Check-in:

- What commitment did I drop or reduce? _____
- What enjoyable activity did I bring back? _____
- Did I say no to something this week? _____
- Am I eating at least two proper meals a day? _____

Month 2: Rebuilding Your Foundation

By now, the emergency phase should be stabilizing. This month is about building a foundation that prevents you from ending up here again.

1. **Identify your warning signs.** What are the first signals that you are heading toward burnout? Write down your personal early warning signs so you can catch it next time. - My first warning sign is: _____ - My second warning sign is: _____ - My third warning sign is: _____
1. **Build recovery into your routine,** not as an afterthought but as a priority. Schedule it the same way you schedule classes and study time.

1. **Set boundaries around your time and energy.** This might mean saying no to social obligations, limiting how much you check email, or telling a professor you need an extension.
1. **Regularly check in with yourself:** "How am I doing, really?" Not how you are performing, but how you are feeling.
1. **Maintain your support network.** Burnout thrives in isolation. Keep talking to the people who know what you are going through.

Month 3+: Sustainable Habits

1. **Weekly check-in ritual.** Every Sunday, spend 10 minutes asking yourself: What drained me this week? What restored me? What do I need next week?
2. **Monthly boundary review.** Are the boundaries I set still holding? Have new demands crept in?
3. **Watch for relapse signs** and intervene early. Burnout has a pattern of returning if the underlying conditions do not change.
4. **Celebrate your recovery.** You did something hard. Acknowledge it.

Section 4: Preventing Future Burnout

The Sustainable Success Model

Success is not about grinding until you break. It is about finding a pace you can maintain over the long term. Ask yourself:

- "Can I maintain this pace for the next six months?"
- "Am I sacrificing my health for my grades?"
- "What would I tell a friend who was this exhausted?"
- "Am I doing this because I want to, or because I think I should?"
- "Who am I trying to prove something to?"

Your Non-Negotiables Template

Write down the things that are non-negotiable for your wellbeing. These are the things you protect even when everything else gets busy. Be specific.

1. _____ (example: 7 hours of sleep every night)
2. _____ (example: one full day off per week)
3. _____ (example: eating three meals a day)
4. _____ (example: talking to my best friend at least once a week)
5. _____ (example: 20 minutes of movement every day)

Now write down what you will do when these non-negotiables are threatened:

"When I notice I am skipping my non-negotiables, I will _____."

"The person I will reach out to for accountability is _____."

The Burnout Prevention Checklist

Review this monthly. If you check more than three of these, it is time to intervene before burnout returns.

- [ ] I have been sleeping less than 7 hours for more than a week
- [ ] I skipped my non-negotiables more than twice this week
- [ ] I feel resentful about my responsibilities
- [ ] I have been canceling social plans to work
- [ ] I am relying on caffeine or sugar to function
- [ ] I feel guilty when I rest
- [ ] I cannot remember the last time I did something just for fun
- [ ] I have been snapping at people I care about
- [ ] I feel like I am falling behind no matter how hard I try

A Final Word

Burnout is not a character flaw. It is a signal that something in your life needs to change. And the fact that you are reading this, that you are looking for a way forward, tells me you already have the strength to recover.

Be patient with yourself. Recovery is not linear. There will be good days and hard days. But you are not going back to the way things were. You are building something better.

If you need support along the way, please reach out. You do not have to do this alone.

Dr. Hala Ali *Mama Hala Consulting*

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